India’s efforts toward its own rapprochement with China. For Indian policymakers, a better relationship with China could somewhat reduce their need for superpower benefactors, which was especially important because of Indian overdependence on Moscow (for this reason they had persisted in trying to improve relations with Beijing despite knowing that Moscow would not be thrilled).[49] Furthermore, a Sino-Indian rapprochement could help ease what had been a source of strain between India and the US. Finally, it might limit Sino-Pakistan relations and neutralize Sino-Bangladesh ties.[50]

Thus India once again made clear its interest in talking to China. Gandhi encouraged, or at least did not discourage, meetings between low-level Chinese and Indian officials.[51] Publicly, too, she asserted after the Indian peaceful nuclear explosion in 1974, “We obviously want friendship.… We have always been ready to do anything on the basis of equality for reestablishing normalcy. We welcome friendship with China. But it has to be a two-way affair.”[52] Indian officials used the US as a source of information about China, constantly asking American officials for their assessments of the Chinese attitude. They also repeatedly asserted to American officials their desire for improved Sino-Indian relations, hoping that the US would pass this message on to China. Furthermore, they urged their US counterparts to indicate to Chinese officials that a Sino-Indian rapprochement was a good idea.

Kissinger, in turn, told the Indian foreign minister that the US would welcome—and not create problems for—a potential Sino-Indian rapprochement. He noted to Indian officials that the US had told Chinese policymakers that India was not a Soviet stooge and was ready to normalize relations with China. Kissinger even agreed to encourage China toward better Sino-Indian relations, but cautioned that the US might have limited leverage on this front.[53]

The secretary of state had two somewhat competing perspectives on how a potential Sino-Indian rapprochement would affect US interests. On the one hand, American policymakers believed that Sino-Indian rapprochement could limit Soviet influence in the subcontinent and Asia on the whole. Moreover, if Sino-Indian relations did not improve while Sino-US relations progressed, this would likely only push Delhi closer to Moscow. Intelligence analysts had stressed, “China is the most important determinant